

Closing the Hand

Practice Three · Upper-Limb Function · Full Script · 5 minutes (audio) / full script below

The audio version of this practice uses a shorter, condensed reading of this script. This is the complete text, with all four phases, for reading alongside the audio or using on its own.

Opening · Breath and Light · 3 minutes

Find a position that feels comfortable. Whatever that looks like today. Sitting, lying back, in your chair, in bed. Let your hands rest somewhere easy. If your palms can face up, let them.

You can hear these words. You're breathing, in and out, without needing to think about it. And as you notice that breath, you're already beginning.

Take a slow breath in through your nose, and let it out through your mouth. Again. Slower. Let your breathing find its own rhythm.

Bring your attention to the top of your head. The crown. Just above it, imagine a soft point of light. Feel it, the way you'd feel warm sun on your head.

On your next breath in, the light enters. Warm. Settling into the top of your head. Each breath in, brighter. Each breath out, deeper.

Phase One · The Ideal Being · 3 minutes

A figure begins to appear in front of you. Whoever this figure is for you is right. Watch them. Their hand begins to move — slowly. Fingers curling in. Thumb meeting the first finger. A gentle closing. The hand opening again. And closing.

Now the figure moves toward you. Closer. Steps into you. And at some point, you may not notice exactly when, you find you're no longer watching. You are them. Their hand is your hand. Feel it from the inside — the fingers curling, the warmth in the palm, the quiet pressure of the grasp. And opening. And closing.

Phase Two · The Pathway · 3 minutes

Now we zoom in. Into the body itself. Start at your brain — the part that knows how to close your hand is still there, still working. Follow the signal as it travels down. Through the back of your skull. Into the spinal cord. Down past your shoulders, to the spot that controls closing your hand.

Feel the signal turn here. Out into the nerve that runs down your arm. Into the muscle deep inside your forearm — the one that pulls the fingers closed.

Now send the gentle intention to close your hand. No forcing. Just the sending. Whatever happens or doesn't happen on the outside doesn't matter. The signal is real. It's the sending that counts. With each closing, the pathway becomes a little more familiar. Feel the whole pathway. Brain to spinal cord. Spinal cord to nerve. Nerve to muscle. Muscle to fingers. Yours.

Closing · Breath and Light · 3 minutes

Come back to your breath. The light is still at the top of your head. The work you've just done is settling in. The signals you sent down the pathway are real. Your brain records this the way it records any practice. It keeps working after the session ends.

Your body moves through natural rhythms all day. About every 90 minutes, your mind drifts. When you feel that drift — you can simply return, for a breath or two, to the feeling of the hand closing.

At night, as you drift toward sleep, the practice is especially strong. A few breaths as you're falling asleep carries the work into your dreams. The same is true when you first wake.

Take one more slow breath in. Let it out. Notice the room around you. The light is yours. The pathway is yours. The practice keeps going. Thank you.

This practice is part of the Guided Imagery Programme at livingbeyondsci.com, free to use. It is not a substitute for medical advice, and does not claim to reverse or cure spinal cord injury. If any part of it increases discomfort, stop and try a different practice.